mindset of giving priority to ‘development expenditure’ and squeezing sovereign and public goods functions, which were earlier consigned to the dustbin of the so-called ‘non-Plan’ category.

The inadequacy of these allocations gets exposed during challenging situations—for instance, the lack of adequate defence equipment during war; the inefficacy of response teams during national disasters; and poor health infrastructure during the pandemic. It is also not unusual to see overloaded hospitals, hugely deficient pollution control apparatus or overcrowded courts.

There is a case to improve the productivity of some public expenditure, but in general the gross inadequacy of allocations for these services has to be remedied for better governance and public welfare.